

MODULE 24 / 40

Eastern Towhee

Pipilo erythrophthalmus

QUICK STATS

Length	6.8 – 8.2 in (17 – 21 cm)
Wingspan	7.9 – 11.0 in (20 – 28 cm)
Weight	1.1 – 1.8 oz (32 – 53 g)
Lifespan	Up to 12 years (avg. 3 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Eastern Towhee is one of the most boldly plumaged and charismatic ground birds of the eastern United States — a large, striking sparrow whose jet-black hood, warm rufous-orange flanks, and clean white belly create one of the most elegant color combinations of any North American songbird. Its vivid red eye is startling at close range. The Eastern Towhee is primarily a bird of dense undergrowth, heard far more often than it is seen — its loud, emphatic "drink-your-teeeeee" song rings from thickets across the eastern woodlands from spring through summer. At feeders it appears mainly in winter, scratching vigorously beneath shrubs for spilled seed.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Eastern Towhee is found across the eastern United States, from southern Canada south to Florida and west to the Great Plains. It inhabits dense shrubby undergrowth: forest edges with thick brush, overgrown fields, bramble thickets, woodland clearings, suburban gardens with dense native plantings, and pine-oak barrens. It is a permanent resident in the South and a summer resident in the North, with northern populations moving south in winter. It is closely associated with areas of deep leaf litter beneath dense low vegetation.

DIET & FEEDING

- White millet and cracked corn scattered on the ground
- Black-oil sunflower seeds picked up from beneath feeders
- Wild weed seeds and grass seeds scratched from leaf litter
- Wild berries: blackberry, blueberry, serviceberry, pokeweed
- Insects, spiders, millipedes, and earthworms
- Acorns and small nuts broken open on the ground

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

The Eastern Towhee's most characteristic behavior is its vigorous double-scratch foraging technique — a powerful two-footed backward kick that hurls leaf litter aside to expose seeds and invertebrates hidden beneath. This scratching can be heard from a considerable distance and is often the first indication that a towhee is nearby. Towhees are mostly solitary outside the breeding season, spending their time in dense undergrowth where they are difficult to observe. Males are territorial and persistent singers, often delivering their song from the top of a tall shrub — one of the few occasions when this secretive species is easily visible.

NESTING & BREEDING

Eastern Towhees nest on or very near the ground, placing their bulky cup nest of leaves, bark strips, and grasses in a shallow depression concealed beneath dense shrubs or in a grass clump. The female builds the nest and incubates 3–4 creamy white eggs with reddish-brown spots for 12–13 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 10–12 days. The species raises 2–3 broods per season. Eastern Towhees are frequent cowbird hosts, and their ground-level nests suffer high predation rates.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Eastern Towhee's song is one of the most recognizable in eastern North America — a clear, emphatic "drink-your-teeeeee" with the final note a long, buzzy trill rising in pitch. Males sing persistently from spring through midsummer. The call is a sharp, rising "chewink" or "towhee" — the source of both the common name and its former name, "Rufous-sided Towhee." A soft "mew" contact call is given in dense cover.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The Eastern Towhee population is estimated at 26 million individuals but has declined by roughly 50% since 1970 — one of the steeper declines among common eastern songbirds. The primary cause is the loss of dense shrubby edge habitat as forests mature and close canopy, eliminating the open undergrowth this species requires. Maintaining brush piles, bramble patches, and dense native shrubs is the most effective way to support towhees in the garden.

FEEDER TIPS

- Scatter white millet and cracked corn on bare ground beneath dense shrubs
- A brush pile near the feeding area is essential — towhees need escape cover
- They rarely use elevated feeders — ground feeding is their only mode
- Plant native blackberries, serviceberries, and viburnums for natural food
- Listen for vigorous leaf-scratching sounds in thickets — the first sign of a towhee

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head & back (male)	Glossy black
Breast sides & flanks	Rich rufous-orange
Belly	White — clean and contrasting
Tail corners	White spots — flash in flight
Female — head & back	Warm brown replacing black
Eye	Red — striking in both sexes

COLOR ME!

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